

Rural Health Transformation Advisory Committee Formal Meeting Minutes

Date: August 11, 2026

Time: 8:15 AM MDT

Location: Thyra Thomson State Office Building, Casper WY

1. Attendees & Roll Call

Advisory Committee Members

- **Heath Steel** – Elected Chairman
- **Rep. Paul Hoeft** – State Representative (Powell)
- **Sen. Charles Scott** – State Senator (Natrona County)
- **Eric Boley** – Committee Member
- **Dr. Travis Riddell** – Committee Member
- **Dr. Brandon Kosine** – Committee Member
- **Commissioner Sue Jones** – Committee Member
- **Mike Hotchkiss** – Committee Member
- **Dr. Angus McAlpin** – Committee Member
- **Tracy Brosius** – Committee Member
- **Richard Brannan** – Committee Member (Joined electronically)

Department of Health & State Leadership Staff

- **Stefan Johansson** – Director, Wyoming Department of Health (Chairman pro tem)
- **Franz Fuchs** – Deputy Director, Wyoming Department of Health
- **Monique McBride** – Chief Policy and Communications Officer, Wyoming Department of Health
- **Jesse Springer** – State Medicaid Agent, Wyoming Department of Health

State Budget Department

- **Christine Emminger** – Administrator, Grants Management Office

2. Call to Order & Organizational Business

- **Call to Order:** Director Stefan Johansson called the inaugural meeting of the Rural Health Transformation Advisory Committee to order at ~8:15 AM.
- **Quorum:** Franz Fuchs confirmed a quorum was present to conduct business.
- **Election of Permanent Chairman:**
 - Nominations were opened for permanent Chairman.
 - Heath Steel volunteered and entered his candidacy.
 - **Action:** Upon a show of hands, Mr. Heath Steel was unanimously elected Chairman of the Rural Health Transformation Advisory Committee.
- **Committee Rules:**
 - **Action:** A motion was made by Director Johansson and seconded to adopt *Robert's Rules of Order Newly Revised for Small Boards*. The motion passed unanimously.

- **Conflict of Interest & Voting Policy:**

- Director Johansson and Monique McBride outlined the conflict of interest guidelines.
- Committee members (including the 9 Governor-appointed members) may fully participate in discussion and debate on all initiatives, applications, and policy items regardless of conflict.
- When taking votes on awards or initiatives where a member or their organization/employer has a direct conflict or direct competition, the member must state the conflict and recuse themselves from the vote.

- **Administrative & Reimbursement Mechanics:**

- Legislative members are reimbursed via LSO.
- Governor-appointed members complete W-9 vendor forms and sign travel reimbursement forms managed directly by the Department of Health fiscal staff.

3. Program Background & Budget Overview

- **Program Overview:** Director Johansson provided background on the Rural Health Transformation Program established under Congressional HR1 (July 2025) and managed by CMS. Wyoming executed its formal agreement with CMS on May 14, 2026.
- **Year 1 Obligation Deadline:** End of October 2026 (executed contracts/agreements).
- **Year 1 Spending Deadline:** End of September 2027.
- **Total Award & Approval Threshold:**
- Total Wyoming RHT Award: **\$205 million** across 5 years.
- Statutorily, the committee must formally approve all individual expenditures over \$500,000. Per WDH recommendation, the committee elected to review and approve all award recommendations regardless of threshold.
- **Unallocated Budget Delta:**
- Initial budget variance left approximately **\$48 million** in unallocated funds due to application volume and federal capping limits.
- The committee was tasked with reviewing recommendations line-by-line and determining a reallocation strategy for remaining funds.

4. Initiative Reviews & Formal Committee Actions

Initiative 1.1: Critical Access Hospital – Basic

- **Qualifying Recommended Applicants:**
- **Action:** Motion passed to approve 15 qualifying hospital applications as recommended by WDH totaling \$36.1 million (Commissioner Jones abstained due to conflicts with Carbon County and Saratoga).
- **Conditional Sustainability Applicants (Sweetwater, South Lincoln, Evanston):**
- **Action:** Motion passed to approve funding conditional upon WDH securing acceptable, formal sustainability plans from each entity.
- **Late Applications (Torrington, Washakie, Platte County):**
- **Action:** Motion passed (with one opposing vote) to accept WDH recommendations to deny funding for late submissions due to low scores and timeline adherence.

- **Excess Swing Bed Capacity Requests:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed (Mr. Boley abstained) to approve excess swing bed requests (Sheridan, South Lincoln, South Bighorn) totaling **\$6,568,685**, contingent on WDH verification of cost estimates and CMS renovation guidelines compliance.
- **Excess Startup Request (Carbon County Memorial):**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to maintain the \$3 million startup cap per hospital, denying Carbon County's request for an additional \$4.9 million in excess startup funding.

Initiative 1.2: EMS Regionalization

- **Standard Qualifying Applicants (Green):**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to approve 5 applications (Cody, Uintah County, Laramie, Converse County and Campbell County Health) for requested amounts totalling **\$10,250,000**. After discussion, subsequent motion to approve four **\$2.2 million** awards for Sheridan, Crook County, North Lincoln County and Pine Bluffs. (totaling **\$19 million**).
- **Additional / Conditional EMS Applicants:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to approve funding for Shoshone Ambulance (**\$2.2 million**) and Johnson County EMS (**\$2.0 million**), contingent upon WDH approving finalized sustainability and tax-base structures.
 - **Action:** Funding for Platte County Hospital EMS was denied as it did not meet regionalization criteria.
 - Single-agency applicants were deemed non-eligible for direct Year 1 funding under current CMS rules.

Initiatives 2.1 & 2.3: Workforce Education Individual Support & Startup

- **Action:** Motion passed to sole-source a master fiscal agent contract with the **Wyoming Innovation Partnership (WIP)** to administer statewide individual and institutional workforce/nursing grants for **\$35,424,820** (Initiative 2.1) and **\$3,193,440** (Initiative 2.3).

Initiative 2.2: Graduate Medical Education (GME)

- **Action:** Motion passed to approve the full budgeted amount of **\$17,712,410** allocated among qualifying entities recommended by WDH, contingent on CMS expense allowability and mandatory 5-year physician service commitments:
 - **University of Utah:** \$9,225,398
 - **University of Wyoming:** \$6,263,043.10
 - **Cheyenne Regional Medical Center (GME Council):** \$2,193,968.90

Initiatives 3.1 – 3.4: Technology Challenges & Statewide Procurements

- **Initiative 3.1 (Technology Adoption Challenge):**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to approve WDH recommendations for the top 10 scoring project applications totaling **\$12,652,243**.
- **Initiatives 3.2, 3.3, 3.4 (Statewide Competitive RFPs):**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to authorize WDH to proceed with competitive RFP awards for:
 - *Statewide Telespecialist (3.2):* **\$3,493,440**

- *Transportation Coordination (3.3): \$828,808*
- *Centralized Billing (3.4): \$2,075,168*

Initiative 4.1: Integrated Primary Care

- **Initial FQHC/Tribal Recommended Applicants:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to approve initial recommended awards for Health West Rock Springs (\$2,251,211.20), Community Health Center of Central Wyoming (\$956,250), and Wind River Family & Community Healthcare (\$3,699,304).
- **Remaining Eligible Applicants:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to fund Bighorn Valley, Warm Valley, Educational Health Center of Wyoming, Cheyenne Health & Wellness, and Community Action of Laramie County at their full requested funding amounts, contingent upon lower-scoring entities establishing WDH-approved sustainability plans and removing unallowable expenses. (*Recusals noted: Tracy Brosius, Dr. Travis Riddell, Richard Brannan, Angus McAlpin*).

Initiative 4.2: Clinically-Integrated Care Coordination

- **County Allocations:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed to approve county-level care coordination allocations as calculated by WDH risk-stratification algorithms totaling **\$3,218,160**.
- **Tribal Allocations:**
 - **Action:** Motion passed directing WDH to engage Northern Arapaho (\$164,700) and Eastern Shoshone (\$102,300) tribal leadership to establish voluntary sole-source agreements for care coordination.

Initiative 4.3: Exercise & Healthy Diet Promotion

- **Action:** Motion passed to approve **\$4,181,087** total budget (\$1.7 million via RFP for a fiscal agent to manage statewide community mini-grants; remaining balance to Department of Family Services for SNAP waivers and Sensible Nutrition).

State Policy Action & Administrative Expenditures

- **Action:** Motion passed to approve **\$819,500** for State Policy Action Support (including UW Presidential Fitness Test contracts) and **\$1,867,792** for WDH Administrative Expenditures.

5. Reallocation of Remaining Unallocated Funds

Following line-item approvals, the committee evaluated the remaining unallocated balance of **\$17,612,195**.

Major Policy Resolution: Remaining Fund Allocation

Motion: The committee directed WDH to contract with one or more fiscal agents to develop and deploy grants targeting **EMS Sustainability** and **Labor & Delivery / Obstetrics Preservation** split as equally as practical (~50/50).

Furthermore, the resolution authorizes WDH to sweep any additional unspent or unallowable

funds from Year 1 contracts back into this fiscal agent pool to maximize Year 1 obligation.

- **Proposer:** Dr. Angus McAlpin
- **Second:** Mike Hotchkiss
- **Outcome:** Motion passed unanimously.

6. RHT Year 2 Program Policy Guidance

- **Primary Care Expansion (Initiative 4.1):**
 - **Action:** Motion passed directing WDH to modify Year 2 application rules to allow non-FQHC/non-Tribal primary care entities to apply, provided they demonstrate strict financial sustainability and serve vulnerable populations using a sliding fee scale aligned with HRSA guidelines.
- **EMS Structure Flexibility (Initiative 1.2):**
 - **Action:** Committee directed WDH to build greater flexibility into Year 2 EMS application guidance, expanding eligible district structures and supporting technical assistance for regional consolidation.

7. Next Meeting & Adjournment

- **Next Meeting Date:** Targeted for **November 4th or 5th, 2026**, in conjunction with the upcoming CMS Federal Site Visit to Wyoming.
- **Adjournment:**
 - **Action:** Motion made and seconded to adjourn. Motion carried unanimously.
 - Meeting adjourned at approximately 1:30 PM MDT.